



Astronomical Society of Australia

Annual Scientific Meeting Bid

Brisbane, July 5-9th, 2027

Sarah Sweet, Holger Baumgardt, Michael Cowley, Rebecca McElroy,
Mitchell Hooymans, Nicole Jenkins, and Vanessa Porchet

On behalf of the Queensland Universities Astronomy & Space Research
(QUASAR) Collaboration: UQ, UniSQ and QUT



Overview

Queensland's astronomy community invites the Astronomical Society of Australia to Brisbane for the 2027 Annual Scientific Meeting. This bid is presented jointly by the Queensland Universities Astronomy & Space Research ([QUASAR](#)) Collaboration, a partnership between the University of Queensland, Queensland University of Technology, and the University of Southern Queensland, and reflects the collective ambition of a rapidly growing community that has expanded significantly since Brisbane last hosted the ASM in 2019. We propose the meeting be held 5-9 July 2027 at UQ's St Lucia campus, one of Australia's most beautiful university settings, situated on the banks of the Brisbane River and well connected to the city by ferry, metro, and bus. The Harley Wood Winter School will precede the ASM over the weekend of 2-4 July, hosted on Bribie Island, a relaxed coastal town approximately 70 km north of Brisbane, offering attendees beautiful beaches, wildlife, and a welcoming community atmosphere.

UQ

The University of Queensland is one of Australia's leading research and teaching institutions and has more than 6,000 staff and 50,000 undergraduate and post-graduate students. [UQ Astrophysics](#) is part of the UQ School of Mathematics and Physics within the Faculty of Science. UQ Astrophysics currently has 4 permanent staff members, 3 postdocs and 15 PhD students and we expect to hire two additional staff members in mid 2026. Our research interests span a broad range of topics, including the evolution of galaxies and their central supermassive black holes, cosmology, dense stellar systems, gravitational waves, and fundamental physics. We are also a part of the ARC Centre of Excellence in Gravitational Wave Discovery (OzGrav).

UniSQ

The University of Southern Queensland is a research-active regional university with strengths in space science, computational modelling, and astrophysics. Astrophysics at UniSQ is based within the [Centre for Astrophysics](#), part of the Institute for Advanced Engineering and Space Sciences, and spans research in areas such as galaxy evolution, star formation, stellar and planetary dynamics, exoplanet discovery and characterisation, and radio astronomy. The group contributes to major national and international collaborations including the Innovative Launch, Automation, Novel Materials, Communications, and Hypersonics Hub (iLAUNCH), Hector Galaxy Survey, and the Vera Rubin Observatory, with recent work including the discovery of an Earth-like exoplanet by former PhD researcher Alex Venner, and the ISS-based agricultural research project launched in February 2026. UniSQ also operates the Mount Kent Observatory, providing unique optical facilities and training opportunities for HDR Students.

QUT

Queensland University of Technology is one of Australia's most innovative research and teaching institutions with more than 50,000 students across its Gardens Point (Brisbane CBD) and Kelvin Grove campuses. [QUT Astrophysics](#), within the School of Chemistry and Physics (Faculty of Science), is a young and rapidly growing group formed six years ago by Dr Michael Cowley, who started with a single HDR student and has since guided five to completion. We now comprise 2 permanent academics, 3 PhDs, 3 MPhils, and 7 Honours students. Our research spans galaxy evolution, star formation, and large-scale structure, using multi-wavelength data and computational approaches. We contribute to major surveys including DESI, ASKAP-EMU, and JWST-MINERVA, and joined Astronomy Australia Limited (AAL) in 2025.

A Commitment to the ASA

In 2027 it will have been 8 years since the ASM was last hosted in Brisbane. Since then, astronomy in South-East Queensland has grown significantly, and we look forward to welcoming the ASA community back to the city.

Queensland has always maintained a strong connection with the ASA, with 49 members across our three institutions. Nearly all our staff members and students are members of the ASA, and this commitment is reflected in the service roles our members have taken on across the society. Dr Sarah Sweet currently serves on the steering committee of the IDEA Chapter. Dr Cullan Howlett served on the SOC of the 2024 ASA ASM. Dr Mark Rigby is a member of the HAAC steering committee. Dr Michael Cowley has recently served on both the EPOC and IDEA steering committees. PhD student Pratyush Das served on the LOC for the 2025 HWWSA.

Proposed program themes

Our proposed program theme "*The Next Decade in Australian Astronomy*" is intended to align directly with the priorities of the 2026-2035 Astronomy Decadal Plan. The broad research representation across our hosting institutions (UQ, UniSQ, and QUT) naturally spans these pillars, ensuring a robust and inclusive scientific discourse across the following core areas:

- *Stellar, galactic, and intergalactic evolution across all scales.*
- *Cosmology, large-scale structures, and the dark Universe.*
- *Extreme physics, compact objects, and multi-messenger astronomy.*
- *Planetary systems, habitability and host stars.*

In addition to this program theme, dedicated schedule time and venues will be reserved for Town Halls hosted by every ASA Chapter, including the new History of Australian Astronomy Chapter (HAAC), to foster maximum attendance and collaboration. To complement the core scientific program, we propose two dedicated special sessions:

- *Advanced Scientific Computing and Data Infrastructure: highlighting modular software toolkits, the shift toward heterogeneous CPU/GPU architectures, green computing, and the integration of artificial intelligence in science.*
- *Community, Culture, and Diversity: focusing on inspiring future scientists, implementing equity initiatives, and elevating Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander astronomy.*

Meeting Structure

We propose to hold the ASA meeting during the Universities Australia Common Week of 5-9 July 2027, with the HWWs held over the weekend of Friday to Sunday, 2-4 July, immediately preceding the ASM. This bid is a collaborative effort between UQ, UniSQ, and QUT, with UQ hosting the primary ASM at St Lucia, UniSQ hosting an event at Mount Kent Observatory, and QUT hosting the welcome event at Gardens Point. The Scientific Program will span 4.5 days (Monday to Friday), with plenary sessions each morning drawing the full conference together, followed by focused parallel sessions in the afternoons to allow deeper engagement with specific topics. Parallel session venues will be co-located to allow quick transitions between rooms, with session chairs instructed to maintain synchronised breaks.

Student talks will all be scheduled ahead of the Conference Banquet on Thursday evening, enabling the Best Student Talk and Best Student Poster prizes to be announced and celebrated at the Banquet itself. We will also incorporate sparkler sessions into the program, giving poster presenters a one-minute slot to introduce their work to the full conference and maximise engagement with the poster sessions.

Venue for the ASA 2027 meeting: UQ St Lucia

UQ's main campus is located on the banks of the Brisbane River in the suburb of St Lucia, approximately 7 km from the Brisbane CBD. The campus is well served by public transport, with frequent and direct bus connections to South Bank and the CBD from UQ Lakes station. The high-frequency Brisbane Metro M2 route provides a rapid connection between the campus and the CBD, running at short intervals throughout the day. UQ is also accessible via the CityCat ferry service. With permanent flat fares across the Translink network available at just **50 cents**, travel between the conference venue, South Bank, and the CBD is both convenient and extremely affordable. There are numerous cafes and restaurants on campus, and the Hawken Drive shopping precinct is approximately a ten-minute walk away, offering several further dining options.

Access to Brisbane Airport is available by taxi or rideshare (approximately 30 to 40 minutes depending on traffic) or via public transport on the Airtrain (note standard 50 cent fare doesn't apply to Airtrain), with connections through the CBD.



Lecture Venues

We have explored several options for holding the ASA meeting on the UQ St Lucia campus. Our preferred option is to have the conference sessions in lecture theatres 222 and 234 of Building 7 (Parnell). These rooms are adjacent to each other, each with a maximum capacity of 208 people, and are wheelchair accessible. Plenary sessions will be held in room 222, with room 234 used for parallel sessions in the afternoons. The registration desk will be in the cloisters at the entrance to Parnell, and coffee breaks will be held in the cloisters and spilling out onto the Great Court in the mild, sunny Queensland winter weather. The posters will be located in the foyer between the entrance and the lecture theatres, facilitating attendees to circulate around the posters during the coffee and lunch breaks. Scheduled sparkler sessions will ensure the posters receive significant visibility. This foyer also houses the [UQ Physics Museum](#) and, most notably, [the Pitch Drop experiment](#) - the world's longest running laboratory experiment, which celebrates its 100th anniversary in 2027. We anticipate this will be a highlight for many attendees.



Additional Rooms

The St Lucia campus has a large number of meeting rooms and smaller lecture theatres that can easily be booked by members of the UQ Astrophysics group, as the week of 5 July falls outside of semester. These will be available for all satellite meetings including the ASA Council meeting, the Australian Astronomical Directors and Heads Committee (AADHC) meeting, and the National Committee for Astronomy (NCA) meeting.

The aerial map below shows the location of the proposed venues and the general location of nearby bus and ferry stops and campus dining options.

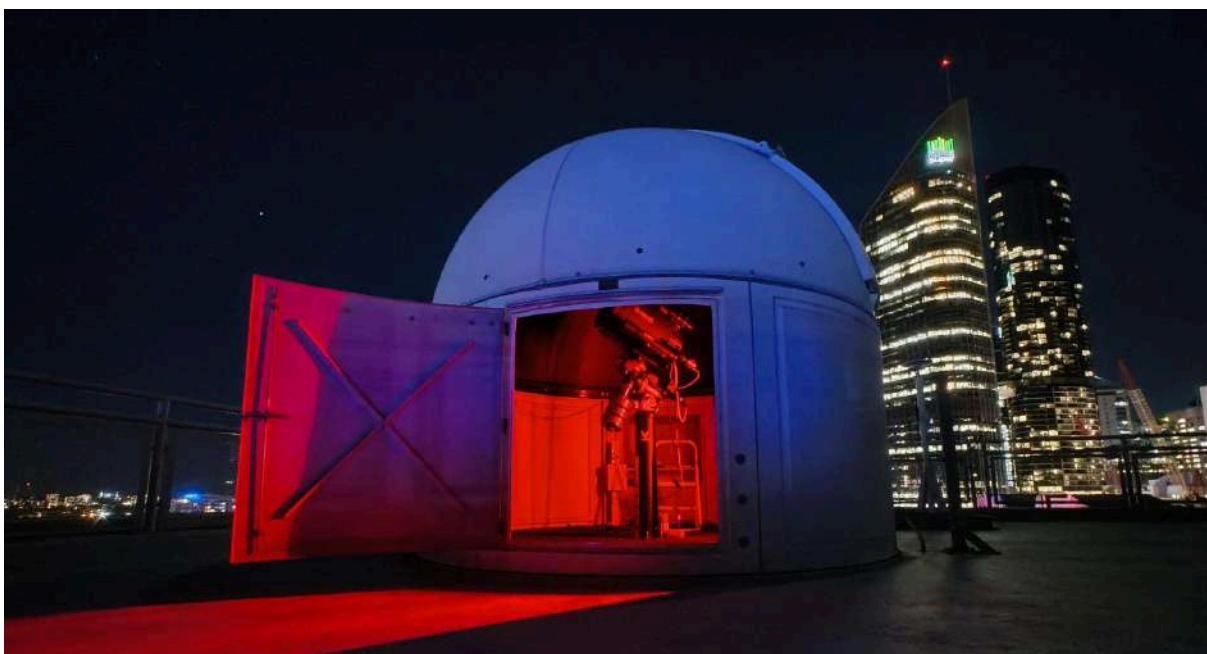


Welcome Reception: QUT Gardens Point

We propose hosting the welcome reception on Monday evening at QUT Gardens Point campus, situated in Brisbane's CBD with easy access from accommodation options across the city. The Gardens Theatre foyer, nestled within the Brisbane Botanical Gardens, offers a light-filled, accessible space with lush garden and skyline views, ideal for cocktails and networking, with a capacity of over 200 guests. QUT Gardens Point is easily reachable from UQ St Lucia by CityCat ferry in around 15 minutes, making for a simple and scenic transition between campuses.



During the reception, members of the QUT Astrophysics research group will offer small group tours of the QUT Astrophysics Observatory, home to a Meade LX850 telescope used for student education, outreach, and light pollution monitoring, giving attendees a hands-on astronomical experience to kick off the week.



Observatory Event: UniSQ Mount Kent

We are planning an optional excursion to UniSQ's Mount Kent Observatory as a highlight of the social program. Located in Greenmount on the Darling Downs, approximately two hours southwest of Brisbane, Mount Kent is a working research observatory and one of the few facilities of its kind accessible to conference attendees. The surrounding landscape of the Darling Downs, with its wide open skies and minimal light pollution, makes it an exceptional setting for a night of observing.

We are currently developing the program for the event, which will include observatory tours and observing sessions on the facility's research telescopes. Attendance will be arranged via a sign-up sheet during registration, with shuttle transport provided from Brisbane. Further details will be made available on the conference website closer to the event.



Harley Wood Public Lecture

We plan to hold the Harley Wood Public Lecture in the Advanced Engineering Building at UQ, the premier lecture theatre on campus with a capacity of 500 people. UQ Astrophysics has strong connections with the amateur astronomical societies across Brisbane and South-East Queensland, and will leverage these networks to promote the lecture widely and maximise public attendance. Our three most recent public lectures each attracted over 400 people, and we are confident of a similarly strong turnout. A suggestion for the Harley Wood lecturer will be submitted to Council at the first Council meeting of 2027 in accordance with the standard process.



Conference Banquet

Brisbane offers exceptional riverside venues for the conference banquet. Our primary proposed location is [Howard Smith Wharves](#), situated directly beneath the iconic Story Bridge on the Brisbane River. This waterfront precinct offers a premium and easily accessible setting with a capacity well suited to our expected attendance, and is readily reachable from CBD accommodation on foot or by ferry. Should Howard Smith Wharves not be available, we are also evaluating the heritage-listed Customs House on Queen Street and the Gallery of Modern Art ([QAGOMA](#)) at South Bank as strong alternatives, both offering memorable settings befitting the occasion.



Other Social Events

We propose a range of social events throughout the week, including a trivia night at South Bank, accessible via a 50 cent ferry ride from UQ, and a sports afternoon and BBQ on the fields at UQ St Lucia. We are also planning to hold the Rainbow Dinner at the [Sir Thomas Brisbane Planetarium](#) at Mount Coot-tha, located within the Mount Coot-tha Botanic Gardens precinct approximately 5 km from St Lucia. The Planetarium's flexible spaces, including a covered courtyard suitable for cocktail functions, a 360-degree full-dome theatre, and an observatory for guided sky viewing, make it an exceptional and memorable venue for this event. The site is fully wheelchair accessible and offers inclusive options for visitors with vision or hearing impairments.



Catering

All lunches and morning and afternoon teas will be provided throughout the conference. All dietary requirements, including vegetarian, vegan, and any other needs, will be accommodated and collected during the online registration process.

Connectivity

WiFi is available freely to all attendees across campus, through Eduroam for those with institutional credentials and the UQ Visitor network for all others.

Accommodation

Brisbane's CBD and adjacent South Bank precinct offer excellent accommodation options to suit all budgets. Options such as the ibis Styles Brisbane Elizabeth Street, Mantra South Bank, and Rydges South Bank will be recommended to attendees, with discounted block-booking rates sought where possible, and a full list provided on the conference website. UQ's on-campus residential colleges offer affordable accommodation within walking distance of the venue for students.

Conference organisation

Our LOC currently comprises seven members: three from UQ, two from UniSQ, and two from QUT, with one student representative from each institution. LOC roles including Chair, Secretary, Treasurer, venue coordinator, and media contact will be confirmed and communicated to Council. The designated media contact will work with the communications offices at UQ, QUT, and UniSQ to promote the meeting and the Harley Wood Public Lecture to the broadest possible audience. The three student members will also serve on the HWWSA LOC. Our SOC will be drawn from across the national community, balanced by gender, geography, and research area, and will include representatives nominated by Council and each ASA Chapter.

Harley-Wood Winter School 2027 meeting

We are currently evaluating Bribie Island as the location for the 2027 Harley Wood Winter School, with the Gold Coast and Sunshine Coast as backup options. Situated approximately 70 km north of Brisbane, Bribie Island is accessible by car or by train to Caboolture Station with an onward bus connection. The island offers a beautifully relaxed coastal atmosphere ideal for the informal spirit of the HWWS, with the protected waters of Pumicestone Passage home to dolphins, dugongs, and turtles, sunset views of the Glass House Mountains, and the surf beach at Woorim adjacent to Bribie Island National Park. Affordable student accommodation options are available across the island and will be listed on the conference website.



Registration Fees

All registration fees include lunches, morning and afternoon teas throughout the conference. Conference venue and WiFi are provided free of charge by UQ.

Registration Category	Early Bird	Standard
ASA Members & NZ Astronomers		
Full member	\$420	\$520
Student / Retired / Associate	\$310	\$420
Non-members		
Full	\$520	\$620
Other		
Two-day ticket	\$200	\$200
Additional dinner ticket	\$130	\$130
Prize speakers	No charge	No charge

Budget Summary

Based on 200 ASM attendees (approximately two-thirds full members, one-third students/concessions) and 70 HWS students. HWS accommodation and transport costs are indicative pending confirmation of the Bribie Island venue. **A full itemised budget is provided as an attachment to this bid.**

Component	Income	Expenditure	Balance
ASM Income			
Registration fees	\$74,510		
Sponsorship (target)	\$20,000		
ASM Expenditure			
Venue & catering (lunches, coffee breaks)		\$35,000	
Welcome reception		\$10,650	
Conference banquet		\$27,500	
Social events (incl. Rainbow Dinner)		\$5,750	
Admin, materials & other		\$16,050	
ASM Total	\$94,510	\$94,950	-\$440
Harley Wood Winter School			
Student fees (70 students × \$580)	\$40,600		
Accommodation, transport & materials*		\$37,614	
HWS Total	\$40,600	\$37,614	+\$2,986
COMBINED TOTAL	\$135,110	\$132,564	+\$2,546

* HWS accommodation and transport figures are carried over from ANU 2026 rates and will be updated once the Queensland venue is confirmed.

We are enthusiastic about the opportunity to host the ASA community in Brisbane and confident that the combined resources and commitment of the QUASAR Collaboration will deliver an outstanding meeting. We welcome any questions from Council and are happy to provide further information upon request.